

RETAIL DISPLAY MANUAL

Standard Operating Procedures &
Merchandising Guidelines

FreshMart Global Retail Corporation

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

Chapter	Page
1. Introduction & Scope	3
2. General Store Layout Standards	4
3. Shelf Planogram Guidelines	6
4. End-Cap & Promotional Display Setup	8
5. Beverage Aisle Standards	10
6. Fresh Produce Display Requirements	12
7. Frozen Foods Merchandising	14
8. Safety & Compliance Protocols	16
9. Seasonal & Holiday Displays	18
10. Digital Signage & Price Tag Standards	20
11. Audit Checklists & Scoring	22
12. Appendix: Quick Reference Cards	24

1. Introduction & Scope

1.1 Purpose

This Retail Display Manual establishes the standard operating procedures (SOPs) for all FreshMart Global store locations. It provides comprehensive guidelines for product placement, visual merchandising, promotional displays, and safety compliance. All store managers, assistant managers, and merchandising associates are required to follow these procedures to ensure brand consistency and optimal customer experience across all 2,400+ locations.

The manual is organized into twelve chapters covering every aspect of in-store merchandising from general layout principles to specific department standards. Each chapter includes actionable guidelines, measurement criteria, and reference tables. Associates should treat this document as the single source of truth for all visual merchandising decisions. When conflicts arise between this manual and vendor-supplied materials, this manual takes precedence unless a written exception has been granted by the VP of Merchandising.

1.2 Scope of Application

These guidelines apply to all FreshMart store formats including: Hypermarkets (40,000+ sq ft), Supermarkets (15,000-40,000 sq ft), Express stores (3,000-15,000 sq ft), and Neighborhood Markets (under 3,000 sq ft). Store format-specific exceptions are noted where applicable.

For Hypermarket format stores, additional guidelines apply to the General Merchandise (GM) sections including apparel, electronics, and home goods. These supplementary guidelines are published in the GM Merchandising Addendum (FM-SOP-2025-002) and should be read in conjunction with this manual. Express format stores may apply the 'Express Exception Protocol' (Section 1.5) which permits reduced facing counts and condensed promotional display footprints where space constraints exist. All exceptions must be documented in StoreConnect.

1.3 Compliance Requirements

- All displays must be set within 24 hours of receiving new planogram directives.
- Weekly compliance audits are mandatory for all store formats.
- Non-compliance on critical safety items results in immediate corrective action.
- Photographic evidence of display execution must be uploaded to the StoreConnect app within 4 hours of completion.
- Regional managers conduct monthly spot-checks with a minimum score of 85% required.

1.4 Roles & Responsibilities

Role	Merchandising Responsibilities	Audit Frequency
Store Manager	Overall compliance owner; approves display changes; signs off on planograms	Weekly daily
Asst. Store Manager	Executes weekly self-audit; manages display setup crew	Weekly WMSA
Dept. Manager	Department planogram compliance; product rotation; signage accuracy	Daily zone walk

Merch Associate	Physical execution of planograms; display builds; restocking	Shift-level tasks
Regional Coordinator	Monthly audits; corrective action oversight; training delivery	Monthly visit
Category Manager	Planogram design; facing allocation; promotional strategy	Quarterly review

1.5 Training Requirements

All new merchandising associates must complete the 'FreshMart Visual Standards Certification' (VSC) within 30 days of hire. The certification includes 8 hours of classroom training, 4 hours of hands-on planogram execution practice, and a written exam (passing score: 80%). Annual recertification is required for all associates. Department managers must additionally complete the 'Advanced Merchandising Leadership' (AML) module covering audit procedures, vendor management, and corrective action planning. Training records are maintained in the HR module of StoreConnect and are auditable by regional leadership.

1.6 Document Revision History

Version	Date	Changes	Approved By
4.2	Jan 2025	Updated seasonal display protocols, added digital signage section	Merchandising
4.1	Sep 2024	Revised safety protocols per OSHA update	Safety Director
4.0	Mar 2024	Major restructure; added fresh produce standards	COO
3.8	Nov 2023	Minor corrections to planogram section	Regional Ops

2. General Store Layout Standards

2.1 Traffic Flow Principles

Store layout must follow the counter-clockwise traffic flow model. Research indicates that 72% of customers naturally turn right upon entry. The decompression zone (first 5-15 feet) must remain free of promotional materials to allow customers to orient themselves. Power walls (right-side displays upon entry) should feature high-margin seasonal items.

2.2 Aisle Width Requirements

Aisle Type	Minimum Width	Preferred Width	Max Display Height
Primary Aisles	8 feet	10 feet	6 feet
Secondary Aisles	6 feet	8 feet	5.5 feet
Perimeter Aisles	10 feet	12 feet	7 feet
Checkout Lanes	4 feet	5 feet	4 feet
Emergency Exits	6 feet	8 feet	No obstruction

2.3 Zone Designation System

Each store is divided into merchandising zones labeled A through F. Zone A represents the front-of-store power area (highest traffic). Zone B covers primary promotional end-caps. Zone C encompasses standard gondola shelving. Zone D designates the perimeter fresh departments. Zone E covers back-of-store destinations (dairy, meat). Zone F is reserved for seasonal flex space that changes based on promotional calendar.

2.4 Fixture Placement Rules

All gondola fixtures must be anchored to the floor using approved base plates (Part #FM-BP-400). Free-standing displays over 4 feet tall require anti-tip brackets. Wing panels must not extend more than 18 inches into the aisle. Clip strips are limited to 6 per gondola section and must not block product facings. All fixtures must maintain 18 inches clearance from sprinkler heads per fire code requirements.

2.5 Lighting Standards

General merchandise areas require minimum 50 foot-candles illumination. Fresh departments (produce, bakery, deli) require 70-80 foot-candles with color temperature of 3000K to enhance product appearance. Promotional end-caps should have accent lighting at 100+ foot-candles. Burnt-out bulbs must be replaced within 4 hours during operating hours. LED retrofits must maintain CRI (Color Rendering Index) of 90 or higher.

2.6 Customer Sightline Management

Sightlines are the unobstructed visual pathways that allow customers to see deep into the store from the entrance. Primary sightlines must remain clear at all times — no promotional displays, floor stacks, or temporary fixtures may block the view from the entrance to the back wall. Secondary sightlines (cross-aisle

views at main intersections) must maintain minimum 4-foot clear viewable width. Department signage (hanging signs) must be positioned at minimum 7.5 feet above floor level to remain visible above gondola tops. Power category signage (Bakery, Deli, Produce) uses illuminated blade signs at 8-foot mounting height.

2.7 Floor Surface & Maintenance Standards

Store floors must be maintained to a high-gloss finish (minimum 70 gloss units on reflectometer). Auto-scrubbing is performed nightly between 10 PM and 5 AM. During operating hours, spot mopping is performed as needed. Floor tiles near cooler cases must be inspected hourly for condensation. Cracked or chipped tiles are reported to maintenance and repaired within 48 hours. Floor decals for promotional events must use approved low-residue adhesive (supplier: SignCo Part #SC-FR-100) and are removed within 24 hours of promotion end date. Floor striping for departments uses the following color code: Blue = Grocery, Green = Fresh, Red = Meat/Seafood, Yellow = Bakery/Deli, Gray = GM/HBC.

2.8 Gondola End Panel Utilization

Gondola end panels (the narrow vertical surfaces at the end of each aisle) are premium advertising space. Allocation follows this priority: (1) Current weekly ad items, (2) Loyalty program exclusive offers, (3) New product launches (first 8 weeks), (4) Vendor-funded co-op advertising. Panel signs must be printed on approved card stock (minimum 14pt, UV-coated) and secured with magnetic strip holders. Hand-written signs are strictly prohibited on end panels visible to customers. Each panel accommodates one 11x17 portrait-orientation sign. Rotation occurs every Monday morning by 8:00 AM.

3. Shelf Planogram Guidelines

3.1 Planogram Compliance Overview

Planograms are mandatory merchandising blueprints that dictate exact product placement on every shelf in the store. Compliance is measured at 95% accuracy or higher. Each planogram is generated by the Category Management team using JDA Space Planning software and distributed via the StoreConnect portal every Monday at 6:00 AM local time.

3.2 Shelf Stocking Hierarchy

Products must be placed following the vertical blocking strategy: brand blocks run top-to-bottom, with premium/national brands at eye level (shelf positions 3-4 counting from bottom). Private label products occupy positions 1-2 (lower shelves) and position 5+ (top shelf). Children's products must always be placed at child eye level (shelves 1-2, 36-48 inches from floor).

3.3 Facing Requirements by Category

Category	Min Facings	Max Facings	Shelf Position	Special Notes
Carbonated Beverages	3	8	2-4	Cold vault: label forward
Snack Foods	2	6	3-5	Clip strips for new items
Breakfast Cereals	2	5	2-5	Kids brands at shelf 2
Laundry Detergent	2	4	1-3	Heavy items on bottom
Baby Products	2	4	2-3	Security tags required
Oral Care	1	3	3-4	Brand blocking vertical
Coffee & Tea	2	5	3-4	Flavor blocking horizontal
Canned Vegetables	2	4	1-4	Label out, pyramid stack

3.4 Out-of-Stock Protocol

When a product is out of stock, the following protocol must be followed in order: (1) Check backroom inventory within 15 minutes. (2) If unavailable, pull forward adjacent facings to fill the gap — never leave an empty shelf space visible to customers. (3) If the gap exceeds 2 facings wide, use approved shelf filler cards (blue for temporary, red for discontinued). (4) Log the out-of-stock in the StoreConnect app immediately. (5) For items out of stock more than 48 hours, request emergency replenishment from DC.

3.5 Price Tag Placement

Electronic shelf labels (ESLs) must be centered below the leftmost facing of each product. The tag rail must be clean and free of old adhesive residue. When multiple sizes of the same product are adjacent, size callouts must be visible on the ESL. Promotional price tags use yellow background with red text. Clearance items use orange tags. All prices must match the POS system within a 0% tolerance — any discrepancy requires immediate correction.

4. End-Cap & Promotional Display Setup

4.1 End-Cap Classification

End-caps are classified into four tiers based on traffic and visibility: Tier 1 (front-of-store, main aisle intersections) — reserved for national brand promotions and highest-revenue items. Tier 2 (mid-store aisle ends) — used for cross-merchandising and seasonal tie-ins. Tier 3 (back-of-store) — allocated to bulk deals and warehouse-style stacking. Tier 4 (side panels/wings) — impulse and add-on items only.

4.2 Display Build Specifications

- Maximum height: 5 feet from floor to top of product for free-standing displays.
- Base pallet displays must use approved riser pallets (Part #FM-RP-200) only.
- Cross-merchandising displays require approval from both category managers involved.
- All displays must include a header sign (minimum 11" x 14") with promotional pricing.
- QR codes linking to digital coupons must be placed at 48-54 inches from floor level.
- Power wing displays: maximum weight 15 lbs per wing, secured with anti-sway clips.
- Dump bins must not be filled above the rim; maintain 2-inch clearance from top edge.
- All promotional displays have a mandatory tear-down date printed on the setup instruction sheet.

4.3 Promotional Calendar Integration

Week	Theme	Primary Category	Display Type	Setup Day
W1-W2	New Year Wellness	Health & Vitamins	End-cap Tier 1	Monday
W3-W4	Super Bowl Season	Snacks & Beverages	Pallet + End-cap	Saturday
W5-W8	Valentine's Day	Confectionery	Floor stand	Monday
W9-W12	Spring Cleaning	Household Cleaners	End-cap Tier 2	Monday
W13-W16	Easter/Passover	Seasonal Foods	Themed island	Saturday
W17-W20	Grilling Season	Meat & Condiments	Cross-merch display	Monday

4.4 Vendor-Supplied Display Rules

Vendor-supplied shippers and displays must be pre-approved by the Regional Merchandising Coordinator. Unapproved vendor materials must be stored in the backroom and reported via StoreConnect. Approved vendor displays must still conform to aisle width requirements and fire code clearances. Vendor representatives are permitted to set displays only during designated windows (Tuesday/Thursday, 6:00 AM - 10:00 AM) and must check in at the service desk with valid ID and current vendor badge.

4.5 Cross-Merchandising Guidelines

Cross-merchandising places complementary products together to increase basket size. Approved cross-merchandising combinations must follow the Category Affinity Matrix published quarterly by the Category Management team. Examples of approved combinations:

Primary Product	Cross-Merch Item	Display Method	Lift Target
Pasta (dry)	Pasta sauce, Parmesan cheese	Clip strip + shelf blade	+12% basket
Ground beef	Hamburger buns, condiments	Adjacent cooler + clip strip	+18% basket
Chips & salsa	Beer/soda multi-packs	Pallet + wing display	+22% basket
Pancake mix	Maple syrup, fresh berries	Inline shelf adjacency	+15% basket
Baby diapers	Baby wipes, rash cream	Wing panel display	+25% basket
Coffee (ground)	Coffee filters, creamer	Shelf blade + cooler tie-in	+10% basket
Charcoal	Lighter fluid, grilling tools	Pallet + floor stack	+30% basket

4.6 Display Performance Tracking

Every promotional display must have a performance tracking card (Form FM-DPT-01) attached to its base or rear panel. The card records: setup date, planned teardown date, weekly unit movement, and final ROI calculation. Department managers photograph displays at setup and teardown for the display performance database. Displays not meeting minimum performance thresholds (50% of projected units sold by midpoint) may be relocated or replaced early with Regional Coordinator approval. Top-performing displays (150%+ of projection) are documented as best practices and shared in the monthly merchandising newsletter.

4.7 Impulse Merchandise Zones

Impulse zones are high-traffic areas designed to capture unplanned purchases. The primary impulse zone is the checkout queue area (last 12 feet before the register). Secondary zones include: aisle power wings, entrance vestibule displays, and restroom corridor shelving. Products in impulse zones must be: (a) priced under \$5.99, (b) small enough to add to an existing cart without rearranging, (c) visually appealing with strong packaging design, and (d) high-margin (minimum 45% gross margin). Category rotation in checkout impulse zones follows a 4-week cycle: Week 1 - Confectionery, Week 2 - Salty snacks, Week 3 - Beverages (single-serve), Week 4 - Seasonal/novelty items.

5. Beverage Aisle Standards

5.1 Cold Vault Management

The cold vault (refrigerated beverage section) must maintain a temperature range of 34-38°F (1-3°C). All products must be front-faced with labels visible. The cold vault is restocked using the FIFO (First In, First Out) rotation method. Maximum door opening time for restocking is 10 minutes per section to maintain temperature compliance. Condensation on doors must be addressed immediately — report to maintenance if anti-fog heaters malfunction.

5.2 Carbonated Soft Drink (CSD) Placement

CSDs follow a brand-block vertical merchandising strategy. Coca-Cola products occupy the first 3 door sections (left to right when facing the vault). PepsiCo products occupy sections 4-6. Private label and regional brands fill sections 7-8. Energy drinks are positioned in sections 9-10 at eye level. Water and enhanced water products are placed in the final 2-3 sections. All 2-liter and multi-pack items are on the bottom shelf.

5.3 Ambient Beverage Shelving

Ambient (room temperature) beverages are merchandised on standard gondola shelving adjacent to the cold vault. The flow moves from single-serve (left) to multi-pack (right). Large format packs (24-pack, 36-pack) are floor-stacked on the bottom shelf or on approved riser pallets in front of the gondola. Maximum stack height for floor displays: 3 cases for 12-packs, 2 cases for 24-packs.

5.4 Alcoholic Beverage Compliance

Where state/local laws permit alcohol sales: all alcoholic beverages must be in a clearly delineated section with appropriate signage ("You must be 21 to purchase alcohol"). Beer and wine coolers are in the cold vault's designated alcohol section. Spirits (where permitted) are in a locked cabinet or behind-counter display. No alcoholic beverages may be cross-merchandised with non-alcohol products. Age verification signage must be visible from 10 feet away. Security cameras must cover the entire alcohol section.

5.5 Beverage Cooler Cleaning Schedule

Task	Frequency	Responsible	Duration
Wipe door glass (interior/exterior)	Daily	Beverage Associate	15 min
Clean shelf rails and price channels	Weekly	Beverage Associate	45 min
Deep clean condenser coils	Monthly	Maintenance	2 hours
Temperature calibration check	Weekly	Dept. Manager	10 min
Replace LED lighting strips	As needed	Maintenance	30 min
Full cooler reset and defrost	Quarterly	Maintenance + Vendor	4 hours

6. Fresh Produce Display Requirements

6.1 Quality Standards

All produce on display must meet FreshMart Grade A standards: no visible bruising, wilting, or discoloration. Culling rounds must be performed every 2 hours during operating hours. Culled items below Grade B are discarded; Grade B items may be transferred to the prepared foods department for same-day use with department manager approval. Produce shrink target is below 4.5% of department sales.

6.2 Display Temperature Zones

Product Category	Display Temp	Humidity	Max Display Time	Misting
Leafy Greens	34-38°F	90-95%	24 hours	Yes - every 30 min
Root Vegetables	45-50°F	85-90%	72 hours	No
Tropical Fruits	55-60°F	85-90%	48 hours	No
Berries	32-36°F	90-95%	24 hours	No (damages fruit)
Stone Fruits	38-42°F	85-90%	48 hours	No
Citrus	45-48°F	85-90%	96 hours	No
Herbs (fresh cut)	34-38°F	90-95%	12 hours	Yes - every 20 min

6.3 Wet Rack & Table Arrangement

Wet racks (misted display cases) are reserved for leafy greens, herbs, and green onions. Products on wet racks must be arranged using the waterfall technique — product cascades forward and downward, creating visual abundance. Tables use the basket display method with products mounded to 150% of container height at center, sloping to edges. Color blocking is mandatory: arrange by color spectrum (red > orange > yellow > green > purple) to create visual impact. Every display table must have a chalkboard-style sign with product name, origin, and price per pound/each.

6.4 Organic & Specialty Produce

Organic produce must be physically separated from conventional products by a minimum of 12 inches or by a clearly labeled divider. Organic items use green price tags; conventional use white. Local farm partnerships (within 100-mile radius) receive dedicated endcap space with farm story cards including farmer photo, farm name, distance from store, and farming practices. Local items are restocked same-day from farm deliveries where possible.

7. Frozen Foods Merchandising

7.1 Freezer Case Management

All freezer cases must maintain a temperature of -10°F to 0°F (-23°C to -18°C). The load line (maximum fill level) on upright freezer doors must never be exceeded — product stacked above the load line blocks air circulation and causes temperature spikes. Open coffin-style freezers must not be filled above 2 inches below the rim. Temperature logs are recorded automatically via IoT sensors every 15 minutes and reviewed by department managers daily.

7.2 Product Arrangement Strategy

Frozen food follows a meal-solution adjacency model: frozen entrees are adjacent to frozen vegetables, which are adjacent to frozen potatoes/sides. Ice cream and frozen desserts occupy a separate aisle section from meal items. Frozen breakfast items (waffles, breakfast sandwiches) are grouped together near the frozen juice section. Private label frozen items are placed at eye level (shelf position 3-4) per corporate strategy to drive margin.

7.3 Door Merchandising Standards

- Each freezer door must have a clear, unobstructed view of products — no condensation buildup.
- Door gaskets are inspected weekly; damaged gaskets are replaced within 24 hours.
- Suction-cup signage on freezer doors is prohibited — use approved magnetic sign holders only.
- Maximum 2 promotional clings per door, positioned in upper-left corner, not exceeding 20% of glass area.
- Night covers must be deployed 30 minutes after store closing to conserve energy.
- LED case lighting must illuminate all shelves evenly — no dark spots permitted.

7.4 Frozen Food Rotation

FIFO rotation is critical in frozen foods. New stock is placed behind existing stock. Products within 30 days of expiration are moved to a clearly marked 'Reduced for Quick Sale' section at the end of the frozen aisle with a minimum 30% discount. Items within 7 days of expiration are pulled and donated to the FreshMart community food bank program if quality standards are met. No expired product may remain on the sales floor under any circumstances.

7.5 Ice Cream & Frozen Novelty Standards

Ice cream requires a dedicated freezer section maintained at -15°F to -10°F (colder than standard frozen foods) to prevent texture degradation. Premium ice cream brands (pints) occupy the eye-level shelf in upright freezers with clear door visibility. Multi-packs and economy sizes are on lower shelves. Novelty items (ice cream bars, sandwiches, cones) are grouped by brand and merchandised in coffin-style open freezers near the aisle entrance for impulse visibility. Seasonal flavors receive temporary shelf expansion (+2 facings) during peak summer months (June-August). All ice cream products must be checked for freezer burn weekly; damaged items are marked down 50% or pulled if quality is unacceptable.

7.6 Frozen Meal Solutions Center

Each store designates a 'Frozen Meal Solutions' section featuring complete meal bundles. This section is positioned at the front of the frozen aisle for maximum visibility. Displays include recipe cards (printed on waterproof stock) showing how to combine 2-3 frozen items into a complete meal. Example bundles: 'Italian Night' (frozen garlic bread + frozen lasagna + frozen vegetables), 'Taco Tuesday' (frozen taco shells + frozen seasoned beef + frozen peppers/onions). Bundles are priced 10-15% below individual item sum. Solution center inventory is reviewed weekly and refreshed monthly with new recipe themes. Digital screens above the solution center display 30-second cooking tutorials on loop.

8. Safety & Compliance Protocols

■ **CRITICAL:** All safety protocols in this chapter are mandatory. Non-compliance may result in disciplinary action up to and including termination.

8.1 Display Stability Requirements

All free-standing displays must pass the 'push test' — a display must withstand 25 lbs of horizontal force at its highest point without tipping. Stack displays must be pyramidal (wider base, narrower top). Maximum height for any customer-accessible display is 6 feet. Displays above 6 feet are permitted only in non-customer areas (above the top shelf of perimeter walls) and must be secured with safety strapping.

8.2 Fire Safety Compliance

Requirement	Standard	Inspection Frequency
Sprinkler head clearance	18 inches minimum below	Daily visual check
Exit path clearance	6 feet unobstructed width	Every shift change
Fire extinguisher access	36 inches clearance around	Weekly inspection
Electrical panel access	3 feet clearance in front	Daily visual check
Flammable item storage	Below 4 feet height, away from heat	Weekly audit
Emergency lighting	Functional backup battery	Monthly test

8.3 Hazardous Materials Handling

Household chemicals, automotive fluids, and pesticides must be stored on bottom shelves only (gravity containment principle). These items require secondary containment trays on shelving units. Leaking containers must be isolated immediately using spill kit (located at end of each chemical aisle). SDS (Safety Data Sheets) must be accessible within 30 seconds — stored in the red binder at the department manager's station and digitally on StoreConnect.

8.4 Ergonomic Stacking Limits

No single associate should lift more than 50 lbs without assistance or mechanical aid. Products over 25 lbs must be stocked on shelves below waist height (below 36 inches). Case stacking in backroom staging areas: maximum 5 cases high for items under 20 lbs, 3 cases high for items 20-40 lbs, 1 case high for items over 40 lbs. Team lifts required for any item over 75 lbs.

8.5 Slip and Fall Prevention

Wet floor signs must be deployed within 30 seconds of any spill. Spills must be cleaned within 5 minutes. The produce department must have a dedicated floor mat at the misting station. All associates must wear slip-resistant footwear meeting ASTM F2913 standard. Weekly floor inspection reports are filed by the safety coordinator every Friday by 5 PM.

8.6 Child Safety in Display Areas

Displays accessible to children must meet enhanced safety standards. No display in a child-accessible area (below 48 inches) may contain: glass containers, sharp-edged packaging, small parts that pose choking hazards, or heavy items that could cause injury if pulled down. Candy and toy displays at checkout must be secured so individual items cannot be pulled causing a cascade. Coin-operated machines and vending displays near the entrance must be bolted to the floor with anti-tip brackets. Shopping cart corrals must have child safety signage reminding parents to use cart seat belts.

8.7 Recall Product Removal Procedure

When a product recall notification is received via StoreConnect alert (Priority 1 — Red Banner): (1) Immediately pull all affected SKUs from sales floor and backroom — target completion within 60 minutes of notification. (2) Segregate recalled product in designated quarantine area (backroom shelf labeled 'RECALL - DO NOT SELL' with red tape). (3) Scan each unit's barcode into the recall tracking module for inventory reconciliation. (4) Replace shelf space with adjacent product facings — never leave empty space that could alert customers to an issue. (5) Store Manager must confirm 100% removal in StoreConnect within 2 hours. (6) Recalled product is held until vendor pickup or destruction instructions are received from Corporate Quality Assurance. Under no circumstances may recalled product be donated, discounted, or returned to the sales floor.

8.8 Electrical Safety for Display Equipment

All powered displays (rotating platforms, LED-lit shelving, digital screens, refrigerated sampling stations) must be connected to GFCI-protected outlets. Extension cords are prohibited on the sales floor — all powered displays must reach a dedicated outlet within the cord length provided by the manufacturer. Cord management channels (floor-mounted, ADA-compliant) must be used when cords cross pedestrian pathways. Monthly electrical safety inspections cover: frayed cords, overloaded outlets, missing ground prongs, and overheating transformers. Any display showing signs of electrical fault (burning smell, sparking, excessive heat) must be immediately unplugged and reported as a Priority 1 maintenance request.

9. Seasonal & Holiday Displays

9.1 Seasonal Transition Timeline

Seasonal transitions follow a strict calendar. Holiday displays are set 4-6 weeks before the event and torn down within 24 hours after. Post-holiday clearance occupies dedicated Zone F space. The transition crew (minimum 3 associates per shift) executes the changeover during overnight hours (10 PM - 6 AM) to minimize customer disruption.

9.2 Holiday Display Specifications

Holiday	Setup Window	Teardown	Display Budget	Theme Colors
Valentine's Day	Jan 15 - Feb 14	Feb 15	\$2,500	Red, Pink, White
Easter	Mar 1 - Easter	Day after	\$3,000	Pastel, Yellow, Green
4th of July	Jun 15 - Jul 4	Jul 5	\$2,000	Red, White, Blue
Halloween	Sep 15 - Oct 31	Nov 1	\$4,000	Orange, Black, Purple
Thanksgiving	Nov 1 - Thanksgiving	Day after	\$2,500	Orange, Brown, Gold
Christmas/Holiday	Nov 1 - Dec 25	Dec 26	\$8,000	Red, Green, Gold, Silver

9.3 Back-to-School Merchandising

Back-to-School (BTS) displays launch July 15 and run through September 15. Primary categories include: school supplies, lunch items, snack packs, breakfast on-the-go, and household cleaning supplies. BTS displays use a 'solutions' merchandising approach — grouping items by use case (e.g., 'Lunch Box Essentials' bundles juice boxes, granola bars, fruit cups, and sandwich bags together regardless of home aisle). Cross-department collaboration between grocery, GM, and HBC is required.

9.4 Weather-Responsive Merchandising

Stores must implement weather-responsive display changes based on the weekly forecast provided by the Weather Integration Module in StoreConnect. When temperatures exceed 90°F: increase cold beverage display space by 30%, add secondary ice cream freezer to front-of-store. When temperatures drop below 32°F: feature hot beverages, soups, and comfort foods at front-of-store end-caps. Rainy week forecasts: move umbrella/rain gear displays to the entrance vestibule and increase hot beverage cross-merchandising.

9.5 Post-Holiday Markdown Protocol

Post-holiday markdown follows a strict descending price schedule to clear seasonal inventory: Day 1 after holiday: 25% off all seasonal items. Day 3: 50% off remaining seasonal inventory. Day 7: 75% off — consolidate to single clearance end-cap. Day 14: remaining items are donated or destroyed (food items donated to food bank if within date; non-food items donated to community partners). Seasonal candy follows accelerated markdown: 50% on Day 1 to prevent inventory aging. All post-holiday clearance must be contained within Zone F — it must not encroach on incoming seasonal setup for the next holiday. Christmas clearance

and Valentine's Day setup frequently overlap; dedicated teams handle each simultaneously.

9.6 Cultural & Religious Holiday Sensitivity

FreshMart serves diverse communities. Holiday merchandising must be culturally inclusive: Stores in areas with significant Jewish populations (identified by demographic overlay in StoreConnect) must include Hanukkah/Passover displays of equivalent prominence to Christmas/Easter. Diwali, Lunar New Year, Eid, and other cultural celebrations receive dedicated end-cap space in stores where community demand exists (threshold: 15%+ of trade area population). All seasonal signage must use inclusive language ('Holiday Season' vs. 'Christmas Season' in diverse markets). Religious symbols on signage require approval from the Diversity & Inclusion team. Stores should partner with local cultural organizations for authentic product selection and display guidance.

9.7 Summer Outdoor Living Displays

Stores with outdoor garden centers or vestibule space deploy 'Outdoor Living' seasonal displays from April 15 through September 15. Products include: sunscreen, insect repellent, disposable tableware, charcoal, coolers, and outdoor games. These displays use weather-resistant fixtures (powder-coated steel, UV-resistant signage) and must be secured against wind with sandbag bases or ground stakes. Inventory checks occur twice daily (AM opening and PM mid-shift) due to higher theft risk in outdoor areas. Products displayed outdoors must not be temperature-sensitive (no chocolate, no aerosols above 120°F). End-of-season teardown includes fixture cleaning, inventory counting, and storage in designated backroom location for following year.

10. Digital Signage & Price Tag Standards

10.1 Electronic Shelf Label (ESL) System

FreshMart uses the PriSync 5000 ESL system across all store formats. Labels update automatically via Wi-Fi at 3:00 AM daily and on-demand during promotional price changes. Associates must verify ESL accuracy during morning zone walks (6:00 AM - 7:00 AM). Any label showing 'ERROR' or 'NO SIGNAL' must be reported to IT within 1 hour. Battery life is approximately 5 years; labels displaying low-battery icon are replaced monthly by the ESL maintenance team.

10.2 Digital Endcap Screens

Each Tier 1 and Tier 2 end-cap is equipped with a 32-inch digital display screen. Content is managed centrally by the Marketing team via the ContentSync CMS. Store-level overrides require Regional Director approval. Screens cycle through: promotional video (15 sec), price callout (10 sec), recipe suggestion (10 sec), and loyalty program reminder (5 sec). Screen brightness adjusts automatically based on ambient light sensors. Screens in the alcohol section must display responsible drinking messaging for minimum 20% of cycle time.

10.3 Printed Sign Standards

Sign Type	Size	Color Scheme	Placement	Authority to Create
Regular Price	2" x 3"	Black on white	Shelf edge channel	Auto-generated
Sale Price	3" x 5"	Red on yellow	Shelf edge channel	Category Manager
BOGO Offer	5" x 7"	White on red	Shelf talker	Promo Team
Clearance	3" x 5"	Black on orange	Shelf edge + topper	Store Manager
New Item	2" x 4"	White on green	Shelf blade	Auto-generated
Local/Organic	3" x 4"	Green on cream	Basket/table sign	Produce Manager
Endcap Header	11" x 14"	Brand-specific	Header holder	Marketing

10.4 QR Code Integration

All promotional displays must include at least one QR code linking to the FreshMart app for digital coupon clipping. QR codes must be printed at minimum 1.5" x 1.5" size for reliable scanning. Placement height: 48-54 inches from floor (average smartphone scanning height). QR codes must be tested weekly — non-functional codes are replaced within 4 hours. Analytics from QR scan rates are reviewed in weekly merchandising meetings.

10.5 In-Store Audio & Announcement Standards

The in-store audio system supports merchandising through scheduled promotional announcements. Announcements are limited to 4 per hour, maximum 30 seconds each. Content is pre-recorded by the Marketing team and loaded into the AudioSync system weekly. Store-level live announcements are restricted to: safety alerts, department assistance calls, and store closing warnings. Background music volume must not

exceed 65 dB at any point in the store. During promotional events (sampling, demos), localized speakers may be used at the event station with maximum 5-foot sound radius at 70 dB. Speakers must not face competing brand sections.

10.6 Loyalty Program Display Integration

FreshMart Rewards program signage must be visible from every aisle. Minimum placement: one loyalty program shelf wobblers per 8-foot gondola section highlighting member-exclusive pricing. End-cap displays featuring loyalty-exclusive prices must include the FreshMart Rewards logo (minimum 3 inches wide) and the tagline 'Members Save More.' Digital screens dedicate 20% of rotation time to loyalty messaging. Checkout lane displays include loyalty signup cards (replenished daily). Stores are measured on weekly new loyalty signups — target: 50 new members per store per week. Displays promoting the mobile app download use a dedicated QR code (separate from product-level QR codes) linking directly to app store download page.

10.7 Accessibility Compliance for Signage

All permanent signage must comply with ADA accessibility requirements: minimum 70% contrast ratio between text and background, minimum font size of 24pt for hanging signs visible from more than 8 feet, sans-serif fonts only (approved: Helvetica, Arial, Gotham). Braille equivalents are required on all permanent department identification signs, restroom signs, and emergency exit signs. Price tags must use minimum 12pt font. Promotional signs at child height (below 48 inches) must not contain language or imagery inappropriate for minors. Digital screens must include captioning for any video content with spoken audio. Flashing content is prohibited (seizure risk compliance per WCAG 2.1 guidelines).

11. Audit Checklists & Scoring

11.1 Weekly Self-Audit Process

Every store must complete a Weekly Merchandising Self-Audit (WMSA) by Friday at 5:00 PM. The audit is performed by the Assistant Store Manager using the StoreConnect mobile app. Photos are required for each section. Results are automatically submitted to the Regional Merchandising Coordinator. Stores scoring below 80% must submit a corrective action plan within 48 hours.

11.2 Scoring Methodology

Category	Weight	Score 5 (Excellent)	Score 3 (Acceptable)	Score 1 (Fail)
Planogram Compliance	25%	>95% accurate	85-95% accurate	<85% accurate
Display Condition	20%	Perfect execution	Minor issues	Major deficiencies
Price Accuracy	20%	100% accurate	98-99% accurate	<98% accurate
Stock Levels	15%	<2% OOS visible	2-5% OOS visible	>5% OOS visible
Cleanliness	10%	Spotless	Minor debris	Dirty/unkempt
Safety Compliance	10%	Zero violations	Minor issues noted	Critical violation

11.3 Monthly Regional Audit

Regional Merchandising Coordinators conduct unannounced monthly audits at each store. The audit covers all 6 scoring categories plus additional items: associate knowledge test (ask 3 random associates about current promotions), backroom organization, receiving dock staging area, and promotional calendar adherence. Monthly audits use a 200-point scale. Stores averaging below 150/200 for two consecutive months are placed on Performance Improvement Plan (PIP) with weekly regional oversight.

11.4 Corrective Action Process

When an audit identifies non-compliance, the following escalation process applies: Level 1 (score 70-79%): Store manager submits written corrective plan within 48 hours; re-audit in 7 days. Level 2 (score 60-69%): District Manager is notified; store manager and team lead attend remediation training within 5 business days; re-audit in 14 days. Level 3 (score below 60%): VP of Operations is notified; store receives daily oversight visits from district team for 30 days; personnel review initiated.

11.5 Best Practice Recognition

Stores scoring 95%+ on three consecutive monthly audits receive 'Gold Standard' recognition: plaque displayed in break room, team bonus of \$500 split among merchandising staff, and photo feature in the monthly FreshMart internal newsletter. The top-scoring store in each region annually receives the 'Excellence in Execution' award presented at the National Store Managers Conference.

12. Appendix: Quick Reference Cards

12.1 Daily Opening Checklist — Merchandising

- 6:00 AM — Walk all aisles; identify overnight stock-out gaps and fill from backroom.
- 6:15 AM — Verify all ESL labels are active (no ERROR/blank screens).
- 6:30 AM — Check all end-cap displays for stability and product availability.
- 6:45 AM — Inspect produce wet racks; start misting system; cull Grade C items.
- 7:00 AM — Verify promotional signage matches current ad circular (check StoreConnect).
- 7:15 AM — Ensure checkout lane impulse racks are fully stocked (gum, mints, magazines).
- 7:30 AM — Confirm all cooler/freezer temperatures within acceptable ranges.
- 7:45 AM — Verify digital screens are cycling correctly at all end-cap positions.
- 8:00 AM — Store opens; zone walk with department leads to brief on today's priorities.

12.2 Emergency Display Teardown Procedure

If a display becomes unstable, is damaged, or poses a safety hazard, execute the following emergency procedure immediately:

1. STOP — Prevent customers from approaching. Deploy caution cones within 10 feet radius.
2. ASSESS — Determine if the display can be safely stabilized or must be fully dismantled.
3. NOTIFY — Radio store manager and loss prevention immediately (Code Yellow).
4. SECURE — If product is on the floor, remove trip hazards first. Document with photos.
5. RESOLVE — Stabilize or remove display. Clean the area. File incident report in StoreConnect.
6. FOLLOW-UP — Review root cause with department lead within 24 hours. Update risk register.

12.3 Key Contacts

Role	Contact Method	Response Time
Store Manager (on-duty)	Radio Channel 1	Immediate
Regional Merch Coordinator	StoreConnect message	4 hours
Vendor Relations Hotline	1-800-555-0142	Same business day
Maintenance Emergency	Radio Channel 3	30 minutes
IT Help Desk (ESL/Digital)	1-800-555-0199 or ext. 4411	2 hours

Safety Incident Hotline	1-800-555-0177	Immediate callback
Loss Prevention	Radio Channel 2	Immediate

12.4 Weekly Promotional Changeover Procedure

Promotional changeovers occur every Wednesday evening (after 9:00 PM) or Thursday morning (before 6:00 AM store opening). The changeover team (minimum 2 associates plus department lead) follows this sequence:

1. Print new week's promotional plan from StoreConnect (includes display photos, signing spec, product list).
2. Remove all expired promotional signage from end-caps, shelf edges, and hanging positions.
3. Verify all promotional product is received and staged in backroom — flag shortages immediately.
4. Build new displays per photographic specifications — use display build sheet for dimensions.
5. Install new promotional signage — verify prices match POS system before opening.
6. Take 'after' photos of each completed display and upload to StoreConnect verification module.
7. Walk the full store at 5:45 AM to verify no missed changeovers before customer entry.
8. Report any discrepancies (missing product, wrong signage, damaged fixtures) by 7:00 AM.

12.5 Store Closing Merchandising Checklist

- Pull forward all products on shelves visible from main aisles (zone A and B minimum).
- Remove any damaged or leaking product discovered during closing walk.
- Verify all refrigerated/frozen case doors are fully closed and sealed.
- Deploy night covers on all open-top coffin cases (frozen, dairy, deli).
- Power down non-essential digital signage (leave emergency and directional signs active).
- Secure all outdoor displays and bring weather-sensitive items inside vestibule.
- Set in-store audio to overnight mode (security announcements only).
- Arm anti-theft systems on high-value display cases (electronics, razors, baby formula).

12.6 Abbreviations & Glossary

Term	Definition
BOGO	Buy One Get One (Free or discounted)
CSD	Carbonated Soft Drink

DC	Distribution Center
ESL	Electronic Shelf Label
FIFO	First In, First Out (stock rotation method)
OOS	Out Of Stock
PIP	Performance Improvement Plan
PLU	Price Look-Up (code for produce/bulk items)
POG	Planogram
POS	Point Of Sale (checkout system)
SDS	Safety Data Sheet
SKU	Stock Keeping Unit
SOP	Standard Operating Procedure
WMSA	Weekly Merchandising Self-Audit

12.7 Compliance Sign-Off Sheet

Each store must maintain a signed acknowledgment that all merchandising personnel have read and understood this manual. The following sign-off is required annually and upon any major revision (version change in first decimal place, e.g., 4.1 to 4.2):

Name (Print)	Role/Title	Signature	Date
_____	_____	_____	__/__/__
_____	_____	_____	__/__/__
_____	_____	_____	__/__/__
_____	_____	_____	__/__/__
_____	_____	_____	__/__/__
_____	_____	_____	__/__/__
_____	_____	_____	__/__/__
_____	_____	_____	__/__/__

Store Manager Certification: I confirm that all merchandising personnel in this location have been trained on the contents of this manual and understand their responsibilities for compliance.

Store Manager Signature: _____ Date: ____/____/____

Store Number: _____ District: _____ Region: _____

— END OF DOCUMENT —

For questions regarding this manual, contact the Visual Merchandising & Store Standards department at merchandising@freshmart-global.com or ext. 2200.

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